CENTER FOR COMPETITIVE STATECRAFT AND STRATEGIC POLICY
WP-2026 SERIES · SERIES STANDARDS

WP-2026 ANALYTIC VERBIAGE GUIDE

Version 2.2 — Unified Institutional Edition

Governing word choice, sentence structure, confidence architecture, prohibited language, source attribution, and register alignment across Treasury, State, ODNI, CIA, NSC, DOE, and academic policy registers

VERSION	2.2 — Unified Institutional Edition
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SUPERSEDES	BW Assessment Verbiage Guide v1.0 (domain-specific, March 2026); WP-2026 Analytic Verbiage Guide v2.0 (March 2026); WP-2026 Analytic Verbiage Guide v2.1 (March 2026)
AUTHORITY	ODNI Analytic Standards · CIA Structured Analysis Tradecraft · WP-2026 Style Guide v3.0
APPLIES TO	All WP-2026 series papers, revisions, and new documents across all domains
PURPOSE	Govern analytic register, word choice, confidence architecture, source attribution, prohibited language, and institutional voice across the full series

HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE

Keep this document beside every active draft. Apply it to every substantive paragraph before submission. The guide is organized in seven parts: (1) the governing principle and core drafting rule; (2) the three-part sentence structure; (3) probability and confidence architecture; (4) approved verb taxonomy; (5) agency-specific register alignment; (6) prohibited language taxonomy; (7) section-label conventions and source tier system. Parts 1–3 are the most frequently applied. Part 5 is critical for multi-audience documents.

PART 1: GOVERNING PRINCIPLE AND CORE DRAFTING RULE

THE GOVERNING PRINCIPLE

The WP-2026 series targets a specific register: institutionally coherent analysis that reads as credible across government, academic, and professional policy audiences simultaneously. It does not imitate any specific institution. It demonstrates through precision, structure, and economy of language that the author operates at the analytical altitude of serious institutional producers.

The register is boring by design. Boring is the signal. Rhetorical intensity, emotive language, and advocacy framing are not signs of strong analysis. They are signs that the author is trying to compensate for weak evidence with strong tone. The correct response to uncertain evidence is explicit confidence labeling and stated limits — not louder assertion.

1.1 The Five Governing Principles

PRINCIPLE 1 **Precision Over Elegance**	Every word carries a specific denotation. Synonyms are not substituted for variety. If ‘designation’ is the correct term, it appears every time. Technical vocabulary, once introduced, is used consistently. The prose is not varied. It is exact.
PRINCIPLE 2 **Economy Over Comprehensiveness**	The analytical point is the first sentence of every section and paragraph. No throat-clearing. No ‘this section will examine.’ No ‘it is worth noting that.’ If it is worth noting, note it. The structure delivers what the reader needs to know in the order they need to know it.
PRINCIPLE 3 **Structure Carries Epistemic Weight**	Uncertainty is expressed through labeled confidence levels, not hedging language. ‘This may suggest’ and ‘it seems possible that’ are prohibited. The confidence label MODERATE CONFIDENCE carries the epistemological weight so the declarative sentence does not have to.
PRINCIPLE 4 **Agent Specificity**	Every action has an agent, an authority, and a date. ‘OFAC designated X under EO 14024 on October 22, 2025’ — not ‘X was designated.’ Passive voice is prohibited except for institutional attribution. The passive voice that obscures who acted is the enemy of analytic accountability.
PRINCIPLE 5 **Numbers Are Specific and Sourced, or They Do Not Appear**	‘Approximately 35% of Chinese crude supply transits Hormuz [Vortexa, March 2026]’ — not ‘a significant share.’ ‘Significant,’ ‘substantial,’ ‘considerable,’ and ‘large’ are prohibited as substitutes for specific figures.

1.2 The Core Drafting Rule

Every substantive paragraph answers four questions in this order. A paragraph that cannot answer all four is incomplete and should be revised or deleted.

QUESTION	FUNCTION	MARKER IN TEXT
What is officially reported?	Name the source directly. Attribute factual claims to the specific reporting body.	states · reports · assesses · identifies · indicates
What is assessed from that reporting?	State your synthesis with a probability and confidence tag.	We assess with [confidence] that [subject] is [probability] to…
What remains unknown?	State what the record does not establish. Always explicit.	The public record does not establish… · The available reporting does not permit…
How confident, and why?	Confidence tag based on source quality and evidence completeness — not on how alarming the finding is.	[HIGH / MODERATE / LOW CONFIDENCE] — defined basis stated

PART 2: THE THREE-PART SENTENCE STRUCTURE

Apply this structure to every substantive analytic claim. All three parts are mandatory. A claim that lacks Limits is incomplete regardless of how well the Attribution and Judgment are written.

ATTRIBUTION	*ODNI's 2025 Annual Threat Assessment assesses that Russia maintains an offensive CBW program inconsistent with its BWC obligations and that its threat is expanding.*
JUDGMENT	*These findings support a moderate-confidence judgment that Russia is likely to continue developing capabilities relevant to biological and chemical warfare; the official record is consistent with an active program posture.*
LIMITS	*The public record does not establish operational scope, specific employment thresholds, or the current deployment status of any particular agent or delivery system.*

The three-part structure applies equally to sanctions enforcement, threat assessment, financial intelligence, infrastructure analysis, and policy implications papers. The domain changes. The structure does not.

2.1 Domain-Specific Three-Part Examples

EXAMPLE 1: SANCTIONS ENFORCEMENT

ATTRIBUTION	*OFAC designated Garantex under EO 14024 in March 2022. Chainalysis documented migration of wallet infrastructure to ABCeX within weeks of the designation.*
JUDGMENT	*These findings support a high-confidence judgment that entity-level designation without simultaneous infrastructure restriction very likely produces a 30-day migration cycle with no durable disruption to network throughput.*
LIMITS	*The public record does not establish whether any prior enforcement action deliberately attempted simultaneous infrastructure restriction, or whether sequential approaches reflect institutional constraints rather than a failed simultaneous attempt.*

EXAMPLE 2: FINANCIAL INTELLIGENCE

ATTRIBUTION	*TRM Labs and Chainalysis 2025 reporting documents approximately $39 billion in A7A5 stablecoin flows, attributed to conversion of sanctioned Russian energy proceeds into USDT for dual-use component procurement.*
JUDGMENT	*This volume is assessed with moderate confidence to represent a meaningful but not dominant share of total Russia–China bilateral financial flows; the crypto layer is likely one of several parallel settlement channels.*
LIMITS	*The public record does not establish the precise decomposition of flows between energy proceeds, defense procurement, and financial arbitrage, nor the total*

	bilateral settlement volume including CIPS and mBridge channels not accessible through open commercial analytics.

EXAMPLE 3: THREAT ASSESSMENT (WMD)

ATTRIBUTION	*ODNI's 2025 Annual Threat Assessment identifies an expanding Russian CBW threat. State Department compliance reports document Russian non-compliance with the Chemical Weapons Convention.*
JUDGMENT	*These findings support a moderate-high confidence judgment that Russia is likely maintaining an active program posture relevant to both biological and chemical warfare capabilities.*
LIMITS	*The public record does not establish operational scope, specific agent inventories, deployment status, or employment thresholds. This assessment does not extend beyond what official public reporting permits.*

EXAMPLE 4: INFRASTRUCTURE ANALYSIS

ATTRIBUTION	*IEA World Energy Outlook 2025 reports that the ESPO corridor transited in excess of $60 billion annually in Russian crude oil flows to Chinese refiners as of 2024–2025. No alternative routing of equivalent capacity is identified in the public record.*
JUDGMENT	*These findings support a high-confidence assessment that the Skovorodino ESPO fork is irreplaceable within a 90-day window and constitutes a highest-criticality node under both throughput and irreplaceability axes.*
LIMITS	*The public record does not establish whether interdiction of this node would produce systemic effects on Russian energy revenues or merely redirect flows through alternative corridors not currently visible in open-source energy data.*

PART 3: PROBABILITY AND CONFIDENCE ARCHITECTURE

Probability and confidence are separate dimensions. Both must be applied separately to every analytic judgment. Probability describes the likelihood that the judgment is correct. Confidence describes the quality and completeness of the supporting evidence. A judgment can be high-probability but low-confidence, or vice versa. Conflating the two is one of the most common analytic errors in draft manuscripts.

PROBABILITY SCALE — Use in Judgment Language	USAGE NOTES
Almost certainly	Reserve for claims directly supported by multiple independent Tier 1 sources with no meaningful alternative explanation. Use sparingly.
Very likely	Strong evidentiary basis with no significant alternative explanation in the public record.
Likely · Probably	Preponderance of evidence favors this outcome; meaningful but less-compelling alternatives exist.
Roughly even odds	Evidence does not favor one outcome over another. Use when genuinely uncertain, not as a hedge.
Unlikely	Evidence preponderates against this outcome, but it cannot be excluded.
Very unlikely	Strong evidence against; only plausible under unusual conditions not currently supported by the record.
Almost certainly not	Reserve for claims the record strongly and consistently contradicts.

CONFIDENCE TAG — Use as Labeled Qualifier	DEFINITION AND SOURCING REQUIREMENT
HIGH CONFIDENCE	Claim directly supported by multiple independent Tier 1 sources with consistent findings. Analytic inference minimal. Reserve for empirically grounded factual claims only. Never assert High Confidence on Tier 2 or Tier 3 sources alone.
MODERATE-HIGH CONFIDENCE	Strong Tier 1/2 sourcing with limited but acknowledged inference. One significant gap or ambiguity present.
MODERATE CONFIDENCE	Credible Tier 1/2 sourcing with meaningful analytic inference or a significant unresolved variable. Most judgments in a well-constructed assessment will carry this tag.
LOW-MODERATE CONFIDENCE	Thin but structurally sound inference from indirect evidence. Reasonable alternative conclusions exist.
LOW CONFIDENCE	Primarily analytic inference from limited or indirect evidence. Does not mean the claim is wrong — it means the evidentiary base is insufficient to support a stronger tag.
SCENARIO-CONDITIONED	Claim valid only under stated scenario premises. Not a prediction. Add to confidence label where applicable.
ANALYTICALLY INFERRED	Derived by logical extension from documented premises. Not directly observed. Add to confidence label where applicable.

COMBINED USAGE EXAMPLE

"We assess with moderate confidence that Iran is likely to continue pursuing capabilities relevant to offensive biological risk, based on ODNI reporting indicating ongoing CBW-relevant R&D. The public record does not establish the operational scope or current weaponization status of any identified program."

Probability: likely — Confidence: moderate — Limits stated explicitly. Both axes applied. Attribution named.

3.1 Common Errors in Confidence Labeling

ERROR PATTERN	CORRECT APPROACH
Omitting the confidence tag entirely and relying on probability language alone.	Always apply both axes. Probability without confidence tag is incomplete.
Calibrating confidence to how alarming the finding is rather than to source quality.	Confidence reflects evidence quality. A low-evidence alarming claim gets LOW CONFIDENCE regardless of its policy significance.
Asserting HIGH CONFIDENCE on commercial analytics or think-tank sourcing alone.	HIGH CONFIDENCE requires Tier 1 sourcing. Commercial analytics are Tier 2 and support MODERATE CONFIDENCE at most.
Using MODERATE CONFIDENCE as a universal hedge to avoid committing to a position.	MODERATE CONFIDENCE has a specific meaning. If the evidence is strong, use MODERATE-HIGH or HIGH. If it is weak, use LOW-MODERATE or LOW.
Conflating scenario-conditioned claims with predictive claims.	Any claim that depends on a scenario premise must carry the SCENARIO-CONDITIONED tag in addition to the confidence level.

PART 4: APPROVED VERB TAXONOMY

Use the correct verb category for the correct function. Attribution verbs state what a source reports. Synthesis verbs state your analytic judgment derived from that reporting. Mixing the categories signals analytic imprecision and is one of the clearest markers of an undisciplined draft.

ATTRIBUTION VERBS — What a Source Reports	SYNTHESIS VERBS — Your Analytic Judgment
states · reports · assesses · judges	suggests · supports the judgment that
indicates · notes · identifies	is consistent with · appears to indicate
describes · finds · raises concern about	points to · is best understood as
documents · characterizes · acknowledges	warrants concern · supports a [confidence] judgment that
estimates · projects · records	raises the inference that · is assessed as
flags · warns · concludes	is more consistent with · the available evidence suggests

4.1 Approved Analytic Phrases

FOR ESTABLISHING THE EVIDENCE BASE	FOR NAMING GAPS AND LIMITS
the public record supports	the open-source picture remains incomplete
official reporting indicates	this assessment does not establish
the available evidence suggests	the evidentiary basis varies by subject
for defensive planning purposes	the available reporting does not permit a firm conclusion
the strongest defensible judgment is	intelligence gaps remain
on balance · in aggregate	the principal uncertainty concerns
the most policy-relevant implication is	in the public record
documented open-source reporting indicates	the public record does not permit
the available evidence is consistent with	this paper does not assess beyond
available reporting is more consistent with	the public record does not establish whether

4.2 Exposure and Node-Criticality Language

When analyzing infrastructure, network, or enforcement-related topics, use exposure and susceptibility language rather than instrument-selection or directive language. This is the single most important register distinction for enforcement-track documents.

DIRECTIVE LANGUAGE — Avoid	EXPOSURE LANGUAGE — Use

most plausible policy instrument	primary exposure type
most analytically defensible approach	principal apparent vulnerability
the correct instrument is	available evidence is more consistent with exposure through
authority established	the public legal record appears to support
legal basis established	the public record suggests a legal basis may exist
multilateral track only	very high diplomatic-friction exposure with low apparent unilateral leverage
targeting X would exploit this dependency	node presents supply-chain exposure through X dependency
execute simultaneously	approach simultaneity is more consequential than…
the critical variable is	the principal uncertainty concerns
enforcement framework is complete	the analytical scaffold is provisionally complete pending collection
primary targets	highest-criticality nodes
take down · shut down · kill chain	restrict · interdict · deny access to

PART 5: AGENCY-SPECIFIC REGISTER ALIGNMENT

WP-2026 documents are read by audiences with different professional vocabularies and tolerance for different kinds of precision. The core three-part structure and confidence architecture apply universally. The vocabulary and framing below should be calibrated to primary audience for each paper. For documents with mixed audiences, default to the most conservative register present.

5.1 Treasury / OFAC Register

USE

sanctions efficacy · administrative operability · designation thresholds · compliance exposure · transaction facilitation · correspondent vulnerability · evasion typology · pressure durability · jurisdictional exposure · nexus determination · evidentiary sufficiency · material support finding · knowing facilitation · secondary designation · wind-down notice · blocking authority

AVOID

take down · kill switch · shut down · force collapse · destroy · execute the designation · authority established (without operability caveat) · the correct instrument is · this will halt operations

5.2 State Department Register

USE

coalition alignment · multilateral uptake · diplomatic signaling · retaliation risk · partner coordination · jurisdictional sensitivity · second-order effects · allied implementation variance · escalation ladder · diplomatic cost-benefit · bilateral working group · conditions-based engagement · escalatory threshold · FATF referral pathway

AVOID

force · compel · demand · we must · immediate action required · no choice but to · the only option is · obvious diplomatic solution

5.3 ODNI / CIA Analytic Register

USE

assess · judge · indicate · suggest · moderate confidence · high confidence · low confidence · the public record does not establish · the strongest defensible judgment is · intelligence gaps remain · alternative explanations remain plausible · scenario-conditioned · analytically inferred · the evidentiary basis is · key judgment · principal uncertainty · analytic line · open-source ceiling

AVOID

proves · confirms · reveals · clearly · obviously · undeniably · we know that · it is certain that · the evidence proves · intelligence shows (in a public document) · classified sources indicate (in a public document)

5.4 NSC / Policy Staff Register

USE

policy-relevant implication · conditions under which · escalation risk · allied coordination · interagency friction · implementation constraints · legal-operational distinction · coalition endurance · observability cycle · guardrail · course of action · option space · scenario-conditioned implication · principal uncertainty for planning purposes

AVOID

the administration should · the President must · Congress needs to · urgent action · immediate decision required · no time to waste · the window is closing (without scenario-conditioning)

5.5 DOE / Infrastructure and Technical Register

USE

system resilience · node criticality · throughput dependency · replacement timelines · infrastructure concentration · cascading effects · redundancy limits · energy transport chokepoints · capacity constraint · colocation dependency · dual-use infrastructure · supply-chain exposure · irreplaceability horizon · substitution ceiling

AVOID

destroying the node · taking out the facility · crippling infrastructure · blowing up supply chains (figuratively or literally) · catastrophic (without defined consequence and sourced quantification)

5.6 Academic Policy Register

USE

this paper argues · this assessment evaluates · the evidence base remains incomplete · the framework is intended as a heuristic · scenario-conditioned implications · bounded inference · methodological limitation · competing hypotheses · observable implications · the literature suggests · this finding is consistent with · alternative explanations include · this analysis does not claim to establish

AVOID

as everyone knows · it is obvious that · no serious analyst would argue · the facts speak for themselves · this definitively proves · the only conclusion is · it is impossible to deny

5.7 Legal / JD Register (for authority and operability sections)

USE

the public legal record appears to support · the statutory predicate appears stronger than the public evidence of operability · the principal unresolved issue concerns implementation feasibility · the record does not establish whether this authority could be converted into durable enforcement effect · the nexus determination requires · the evidentiary threshold for · administrative operability is distinct from textual authority · implementing regulations pending · prior analogous actions provide some precedent

AVOID

authority established · legal basis established · this is clearly authorized · the law permits this action (without operability caveat) · courts have approved · legally settled · no legal obstacle exists

PART 6: PROHIBITED LANGUAGE TAXONOMY

All three categories below are prohibited in every WP-2026 paper without exception. They signal different failures. Prosecutorial certainty signals advocacy. Emotive inflation signals poor epistemic discipline. Advocacy language signals the analysis has a conclusion it is trying to produce rather than derive.

PROSECUTORIAL CERTAINTY	EMOTIVE INFLATION	ADVOCACY LANGUAGE
proves · demonstrates conclusively	terrifying · horrific · sinister	the world must · no choice but
confirms beyond doubt · exposes	apocalyptic · nightmare scenario	urgent moral necessity
reveals the truth · undeniably	catastrophic (undefined consequence)	immediate decisive action required
clearly · without question	evil · evil regime · rogue state	everyone knows · it is obvious
definitively establishes	unprecedented threat (unquantified)	must act now · cannot wait
the evidence proves	shocking · alarming (as conclusions)	the only responsible course is

6.1 Extended Prohibited Pattern List

The following patterns are prohibited wherever they appear. Each entry includes the correct replacement approach.

PROHIBITED PATTERN	REPLACE WITH
It should be noted that…	State the point directly. Delete the frame.
This paper argues that… / This section will…	State the argument. The structure announces it.
Clearly / Obviously / Of course	If it requires saying, say it without the modifier.
It is important to… / It is worth noting…	The structure demonstrates importance. Do not assert it.
May suggest / Could indicate / Seems to imply	ASSESSED WITH [CONFIDENCE]: [declarative claim]
A significant / substantial / large share	Specific figure with Tier 1/2 source citation, or omit.
This analysis seeks to… / We attempt to…	State what the analysis does, not what it seeks to do.
X was designated (agent obscured)	OFAC designated X under [authority] on [date].
Going forward / Moving ahead	On [timeline]: [specific projection with confidence label].
Interestingly / Notably / Importantly	Delete. The analysis makes it notable by including it.
This is a complex / nuanced problem	Complexity is shown through the analysis, not named.
Many analysts believe / experts agree	Cite specific analysts with institutional attribution.
The gap is not legal authority but…	A principal constraint is not textual but practical…
The critical variable is…	The principal uncertainty concerns…

Enforcement framework is complete	The analytical scaffold is provisionally complete pending…
Designed to reduce Western leverage	Appears structured in ways that reduce exposure to…
Almost certainly counterproductive	Assessed as likely counterproductive under current conditions
The binding constraint is…	A principal constraint appears to be…
Most plausible policy instrument	Primary exposure type / apparent vulnerability class
Authority established	The public legal record appears to support…
Execute simultaneously	Approach simultaneity appears more consequential than…

PART 7: SECTION LABELS, SOURCE TIER SYSTEM, AND CLOSURE DISCIPLINE

7.1 Preferred Section Labels

Section headers must be descriptive and functional. Argumentative, rhetorical, or question-framing headers signal an undisciplined manuscript regardless of the quality of the content they introduce.

CORRECT — Descriptive / Functional	PROHIBITED — Argumentative / Rhetorical
Observed / Officially Reported	What They're Really Doing
Assessment	The Truth
Strategic Significance	How Dangerous They Really Are
Unknowns / Intelligence Gaps	Hidden Program
Implications for U.S. and Allied Policy	What Must Be Done
Limitations of the Public Record	(none — always include this section)
Analytic Confidence and Evidentiary Basis	How Sure We Are
Scenario Premise and Scope	What We're Assuming
Enforcement Friction Assessment	How to Cripple the Network
Node-Criticality Framework	Target Priority List
Legal Authorities and Administrative Operability	Legal Justification for Action
Coalition Dependence and Diplomatic Constraints	Why Our Allies Won't Help
Scenarios for Defensive Planning	How to Win
Public-Source Assessment	Exposing the Program

7.2 Source Tier System

Source tier is cited at point of use, not only in the bibliography. Confidence labels are calibrated against the tier of supporting evidence. Never assert HIGH CONFIDENCE on Tier 2 or Tier 3 sources alone.

TIER	SOURCE TYPES	CONFIDENCE SUPPORT AND CITATION FORMAT
TIER 1	US Government (EIA, OFAC, DoD, CRS, ODNI ATA, State Dept compliance reports); UN bodies (IAEA, UNODA, UNSCR); primary legal texts (statutes, EOs, regulations); peer-reviewed journals	Supports HIGH or MODERATE-HIGH CONFIDENCE. Citation: [TIER 1 — ODNI ATA 2025, p. 14]
TIER 2	CSIS, RAND, Carnegie, Brookings, Atlantic Council, AidData, SIPRI; IEA WEO, BP Statistical Review, Vortexa,	Supports MODERATE CONFIDENCE. Never cite alone

	Chainalysis, TRM Labs, BNEF; Foreign Affairs, TNSR, Survival; congressional testimony with named attribution	for HIGH CONFIDENCE claims. Citation: [TIER 2 — Chainalysis, March 2025]
TIER 3	Major news media with named institutional sources; trade publications with specific data; think tank blogs and commentary	LOW CONFIDENCE / Contextual only. Never as primary source for consequential quantitative claims. Citation: [TIER 3 — Reuters, March 5, 2026 — contextual only]
PROHIBITED	Wikipedia; scenario-constructed entries; anonymous sources; circular sourcing; sources that are products of the same analytical exercise	Never cite. Remove without replacement.

7.3 Closure Discipline: The Unknowns Sentence

Every major subsection must end with a sentence that explicitly states what the public record does not establish. This is the single most important elite-level drafting practice. It is what separates an institutionally mature assessment from a confident-sounding report. Use one of the following opening constructions:

APPROVED CLOSURE CONSTRUCTIONS — REQUIRED AT END OF EVERY MAJOR SUBSECTION

The public record does not establish…
The principal uncertainty concerns…
Available reporting does not permit a firm conclusion on…
This assessment does not establish…
Intelligence gaps remain regarding…
The available evidence does not resolve…
The public record does not permit a firm conclusion regarding…
This paper does not assess beyond what the public record supports…

7.4 The Weak-to-Strong Conversion Table

Apply this table during revision. For every claim that appears in weaker form, substitute the stronger form. The stronger form states the same analytical content with appropriate attribution, explicit limits, and the correct confidence tag.

WEAKER PHRASING — Avoid	STRONGER PHRASING — Use
China is clearly running a covert biological program.	Public reporting raises compliance and capability concerns regarding China; the open-source record does not establish the scope of any current prohibited program.
Russia definitely intends to use these capabilities.	Official U.S. reporting identifies an expanding Russian CBW threat; the public record does not permit a firm conclusion about specific employment thresholds.
Iran is secretly preparing biological attacks.	ODNI reporting indicates offensive-purpose concern related to Iranian CBW R&D; the public record remains limited on operational scope.

North Korea is an apocalyptic biological threat.	North Korea presents a persistent unconventional WMD risk, including biological-warfare-related concern in official U.S. reporting.
China and Russia are winning the trade war.	Official reporting and commercial data indicate expanding China-Russia energy and mineral trade volumes; assessed impact on US enforcement effectiveness remains a principal uncertainty.
The network was designed to evade sanctions.	The available architecture is consistent with a sanctions-resilience objective; the public record does not establish whether this design reflects deliberate coordination or emergent adaptation.
The enforcement framework is complete.	The analytical scaffold is provisionally complete pending collection, evidentiary validation, and interagency consequence modeling.
This is the most dangerous node in the network.	This node is assessed as highest-criticality on both irreplaceability and throughput axes; the public record does not establish whether interdiction would produce system-wide effects.
Sanctions will fail without multilateral support.	Available evidence suggests US unilateral action is unlikely to produce durable friction for this node class absent EU/UK/Australia alignment; the conditions under which such alignment is achievable are not established in the public record.
The BRI is a debt trap designed to seize assets.	Chinese state lending structures in BRI agreements have created contingent coercive leverage over sovereign infrastructure in documented cases; whether this reflects deliberate design intent is analytically contested.

PART 8: ADVANCED DRAFTING DISCIPLINES

The sections below address four discipline areas that go beyond basic sentence structure and verb taxonomy. They apply specifically to documents that: present analytical frameworks as organizing tools; rely on open-source visibility as an evidentiary base; make claims about policy-relevant effects; or must survive hostile methodological review. All four apply to every applied enforcement, threat assessment, and infrastructure analysis paper in the WP-2026 series.

8.1 Competing Hypotheses Discipline

Institutional-grade analysis does not present a single explanation and then defend it. It identifies the most defensible explanation, names competing explanations, and states explicitly why the evidence favors the leading hypothesis while acknowledging that competing explanations cannot be excluded. This is not hedging. It is the correct epistemic posture when the public record is incomplete. The verbiage guide prescribes bounded inference and explicit limits; the competing-hypotheses discipline is how those prescriptions are applied to explanatory claims.

Every paper that makes a causal or architectural claim should ask: what alternative explanations exist, and what evidence would distinguish between them? The three most common competing hypothesis classes in WP-2026 domain papers are: (1) deliberate state-directed design, (2) emergent market or bureaucratic adaptation, and (3) mixed architecture combining both. A paper that presents only hypothesis 1 without addressing hypotheses 2 and 3 will be attacked by any competent hostile reviewer.

Model Competing Hypotheses Block

> **COMPETING HYPOTHESES: MODEL STRUCTURE**
>
> The observed [architecture / pattern / behavior] is consistent with at least three competing explanations.
>
> **Hypothesis 1 (Deliberate Design):** [State the hypothesis. Describe what evidence is consistent with it. State what it implies for the paper's analytical conclusions.]
>
> **Hypothesis 2 (Emergent Adaptation):** [State the hypothesis. Describe what evidence is consistent with it. State what it implies for the paper's analytical conclusions.]
>
> **Hypothesis 3 (Mixed Architecture):** [State the hypothesis. Identify which evidence it best accounts for. State why it is the leading hypothesis while explicitly noting that the public record does not exclude the alternatives.]
>
> *The public record does not establish which hypothesis best characterizes the actual architecture. The analytical framework in this paper is most consistent with Hypothesis [X] but does not depend on excluding the others. The principal uncertainty concerns [specify gap].*

8.2 Open-Source Visibility Bias

The public record is not a neutral sample of the underlying system being analyzed. It is a selection effect. What is visible in open-source reporting reflects what commercial analytics firms can trace, what governments choose to disclose, what journalists can access, and what adversaries permit to be seen. Commercially legible nodes, registered exchange infrastructure, and named intermediaries are systematically over-represented. Concealed state-directed pathways, pre-

positioned substitute infrastructure, and shell-layered facilitation networks are systematically under-represented.

Every paper that analyzes a network, infrastructure complex, or institutional architecture from open sources should include an explicit visibility bias acknowledgment. The hostile-review formulation is: “the model may be accurate about the visible layer and wrong about the decisive layer.” The correct response is not to remove the analysis but to bound it explicitly with one of the following constructions.

APPROVED VISIBILITY BIAS CONSTRUCTIONS — REQUIRED IN ALL NETWORK AND INFRASTRUCTURE ANALYSIS PAPERS

The public record may systematically over-represent commercially legible or expendable nodes and under-represent concealed, state-protected, or pre-positioned substitute pathways.

This analysis is bounded by open-source visibility; the visible network may not accurately represent the decisive network.

Node ordering reflects the public record’s observability ceiling, not a validated hierarchy of system-wide strategic effect.

This framework is a heuristic prioritization construct derived from open-source analysis, not a validated hierarchy of system-wide strategic effect.

The public record does not establish whether the identified nodes represent the decisive enforcement surface or a commercially visible subset of a larger concealed architecture.

8.3 Friction vs. Coercive Effect: A Required Distinction

Enforcement friction and coercive effect are distinct analytical categories. Friction is a measure of transaction cost, disruption duration, and adaptation burden imposed on a target system. Coercive effect is a measure of whether that friction produced behavioral change, policy concession, or durable strategic advantage. These are not the same, and papers that conflate them will be attacked by any reviewer operating in the Treasury, State, ODNI, or academic policy register.

WP-2026 enforcement and assessment papers evaluate friction-generation potential under stated assumptions. They do not assess whether friction produces behavioral change, nor do they establish that increased transaction costs translate into strategic advantage. Any paper that implies the latter without explicitly noting the distinction will carry unnecessary overreach risk. The correct construction is stated in the approved phrases below.

APPROVED FRICTION / EFFECT BOUNDARY CONSTRUCTIONS

This assessment evaluates likely friction-generation under stated assumptions — not whether such friction would produce policy concession, behavioral change, or durable strategic advantage.

Increased transaction cost is not equivalent to coercive effect. This paper assesses the former and does not assess the latter.

The public record does not establish whether enforcement friction of the type assessed here would produce behavioral change, policy concession, or durable strategic advantage. Those are distinct questions this paper does not claim to answer.

Enforcement friction and coercive effect are distinct. This paper evaluates conditions likely to generate the former. Whether the latter follows depends on political, economic, and strategic variables outside the scope of this analysis.

8.4 Guide Self-Disclaimer: These Are Institutional Heuristics, Not Validated Instruments

The probability scale, confidence tags, verb taxonomy, and section-label conventions in this guide are institutional heuristics derived from ODNI Analytic Standards and CIA structured analysis tradecraft guidance. They are not empirically validated instruments. The probability scale does not produce calibrated probability estimates in the statistical sense. The confidence tags do not map to a formal evidentiary scoring rubric. The verb taxonomy reflects institutional convention, not a formal theory of attribution and synthesis.

This matters for three reasons. First, a paper that applies this guide correctly will read as institutionally credible, but that credibility is a function of register and discipline, not of demonstrated predictive accuracy. Second, applying this guide does not make a paper immune to hostile methodological review; it makes the paper harder to attack on stylistic and register grounds while leaving it appropriately vulnerable to substantive evidentiary critique. Third, the guide prescribes what a serious institutional producer would write given a public-source evidentiary base; it does not prescribe what a serious institutional producer with classified access would conclude.

The guide should be applied in full awareness that its primary value is epistemic discipline and register credibility, not analytic validation. A paper can follow every rule in this guide and still be wrong about the underlying world. The guide is a floor on quality, not a ceiling on critique.

MANDATORY PRE-SUBMISSION SWEEP CHECKLIST

Run this checklist on every WP-2026 paper before submission, commit, or distribution. Each item is a binary pass/fail. A paper that fails any item in Block A or Block B is not ready for submission. Items in Block C are required for applied enforcement, infrastructure, and network analysis papers. Block D applies to all papers. The sweep should take five minutes or less.

BLOCK A — STRUCTURE AND CONFIDENCE (REQUIRED: ALL PAPERS)

☐	CHECK
A1	Every substantive analytic claim follows the three-part structure: Attribution → Judgment → Limits. No claim appears without a limits sentence.
A2	Every Key Judgment carries both a probability word (likely, very likely, almost certainly) AND a confidence tag (HIGH / MODERATE / LOW CONFIDENCE). Both axes applied separately.
A3	Every major subsection ends with a closure sentence beginning with one of: “The public record does not establish…” / “The principal uncertainty concerns…” / “Available reporting does not permit a firm conclusion on…”
A4	All section headers are descriptive / functional. No argumentative, rhetorical, or question-framing headers present.
A5	Every action has an agent, authority, and date. No passive voice obscuring the acting agent. “X was designated” → “OFAC designated X under [authority] on [date].”
A6	Every quantitative claim carries a Tier 1 or Tier 2 source citation at point of use. No “significant,” “substantial,” or “large share” appears as a substitute for a specific figure.

BLOCK B — PROHIBITED LANGUAGE SWEEP (REQUIRED: ALL PAPERS)

Search the draft for each term. Any hit is a failure requiring revision before submission.

☐	SEARCH FOR (delete or convert if found)	CATEGORY
B1	proves · demonstrates conclusively · confirms beyond doubt · clearly · undeniably · without question · definitively establishes	Prosecutorial certainty
B2	terrifying · horrific · sinister · apocalyptic · nightmare scenario · evil regime · unprecedented threat	Emotive inflation
B3	the world must · no choice but · urgent moral necessity · must act now · immediate decisive action · everyone knows	Advocacy language
B4	most plausible policy instrument · most analytically defensible · authority established · legal basis established · the correct instrument is · multilateral track only	Directive / instrument-selection language
B5	enforcement framework is complete · the binding constraint is · the critical variable is · the gap is not legal authority · designed to	Certainty inflation / overreach

	reduce Western leverage

BLOCK C — PART 8 DISCIPLINES (REQUIRED: ENFORCEMENT, INFRASTRUCTURE, AND NETWORK ANALYSIS PAPERS)

☐	CHECK
C1	A competing hypotheses block is present. At minimum two alternative explanations are named. The paper states which hypothesis is most consistent with the available evidence and explicitly acknowledges the others cannot be excluded.
C2	An open-source visibility bias acknowledgment is present. The paper explicitly states that the public record may over-represent commercially legible nodes and under-represent concealed pathways. Node ordering or framework rankings are identified as heuristic constructs, not validated hierarchies.
C3	The friction/effect distinction is present. The paper explicitly states that it evaluates friction-generation potential, not whether friction produces behavioral change, policy concession, or strategic advantage.
C4	No table reads as a targeting matrix or action grid. All tables use exposure language (coalition-dependent exposure, supply-chain exposure, hosting-layer exposure, monitoring priority) rather than instrument-selection language.
C5	All legal authority entries distinguish textual authority from administrative operability. No entry reads as “authority established” without an operability caveat. GENIUS Act, IEEPA, and CAATSA entries include implementing-regulation or coalition-dependence caveats where applicable.

BLOCK D — PRODUCTION AND VERSION STANDARDS (REQUIRED: ALL PAPERS)

☐	CHECK
D1	Version number is consistent across: cover metadata table, document ID field, header, footer, and END OF DOCUMENT line. All five match.
D2	No Wikipedia citations. No anonymous sources. No circular sourcing (citing a product of the same analytical exercise as independent corroboration).
D3	HIGH CONFIDENCE claims are supported by Tier 1 sourcing. No HIGH CONFIDENCE tag appears on a claim supported only by Tier 2 or Tier 3 sources.
D4	SCENARIO-CONDITIONED and ANALYTICALLY INFERRED tags are applied to all forward-looking claims that depend on stated premises. No predictive claim appears as a factual assertion.
D5	END OF DOCUMENT line is present. UNCLASSIFIED // OPEN SOURCE status is stated on both the cover and the final line. The document is consistent with the WP-2026 NOTICE block disclaimer.

END OF DOCUMENT — WP-2026 ANALYTIC VERBIAGE GUIDE V2.2 — MARCH 2026 — UNCLASSIFIED // OPEN SOURCE